varieties—he discovered a profound lesson about human flourishing. Gardening, Singh suggests, is a metaphor for life itself. It demands patience, disciplined attention, and a willingness to nurture and renew what we have inherited from those who came before us. True well-being requires us to respect our roots, tend to our communities with care, recognise that growth is a slow, seasonal process and that there is always renewal.

Learning to See and Listen Across Differences

As a diplomat and public servant who witnessed India's evolution from post-independence scarcity to a confident voice on the global stage, Singh understands the vital importance of bridging divides. Yet, his book shows that true cross-cultural understanding is rooted in much more than policy debates and formal international negotiations. During his posting in Tokyo, photography became his lens for understanding Japan's delicate balance of ancient ritual and technological modernity. Similarly, his immersion in Indian classical music and his custodianship of rare recitals remind us that cultural inheritance is a living art.

Lessons for a Good Life

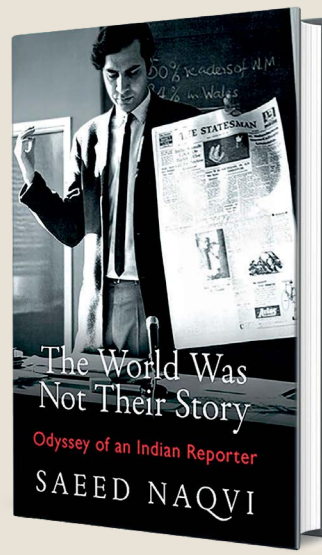
Endeavours ultimately challenges us to rethink our metrics of success. It suggests that a life well-lived rests on three essential pillars: cultivating lifelong curiosity, preserving and renewing tradition, and seeking connection across differences. In an increasingly fragmented and dissonant world, N.K. Singh has given us a generous, warm and deeply optimistic gift. *Endeavours* is an inspiring realisation that our lives are vast enough to hold many dimensions—and that by nurturing them all, we honour not just ourselves, but the shared human story. ■

*— **Baroness Shafik** is a prominent economist and has served as president of Columbia University and chief economic advisor to the British PM. She is the current chair of the V&A*

Witness to Change

SAEED NAQVI's memoir doubles up as a richly detailed history of journalism over the past six decades

In a chapter from the veteran journalist Saeed Naqvi's memoir *The World Was Not Their Story*, we see him interviewing Fatmir Sejdiu (president of Kosovo in the late 2000s). Much to Naqvi's surprise, during the interview, Sejdiu was flanked by two portraits: of Mother Teresa and Skanderbeg, who led the Albanians in the Albanian-Ottoman wars of the 15th century. Naqvi writes:



THE WORLD WAS NOT THEIR STORY: Odyssey of an Indian Reporter
By Saeed Naqvi
SPEAKING TIGER BOOKS
₹999; 568 pages

"Just imagine: a Muslim society with icons! And both the iconic figures being non-Muslim. I asked an American official why US support for a Muslim people has never been advertised in this fashion. He laughed and said: 'So biased has the media been that projecting the US in support of Muslims anywhere will be bad politics.'"

The 86-year-old Naqvi is one of the doyens of Indian journalism, his news agency World Report (founded 1984) bringing stories and images from far-flung nations that Indian viewers had not yet been exposed to. And, as the paragraph above shows, the book is much more than one man's memoir—it is a diligently told history of the past 60-odd years of journalism itself, charting its perils as well as its pleasures. Across the book, as we see Naqvi covering civil war in Sri Lanka, interviewing Gorbachev at the Kremlin or talking to Nelson Mandela after his release from prison, what we are actually witnessing is the evolution of the politician-media dynamic. How world leaders engage with journalists is one of the strongest through-lines of the book, and it has changed dramatically in the 21st century, with the growing power of social media and other online platforms.

There's a lot that young journalists can learn from this book, especially from Naqvi's detailed accounts of overcoming practical constraints and sudden logistical challenges in his practice.

***The World Was Not Their Story* is a genuinely entertaining account of a (professional) life well-lived; highly recommended for everyone really, but especially journalists. ■**

—Aditya Mani Jha